

Chapter 42: The Moment It Stops Floating

Jenny didn't answer him right away.

Not because she didn't have words.

Because none of them felt safe anymore.

Austin stood across from her like he had decided something irreversible inside himself, and was now simply waiting for her to catch up to it.

That was the new feeling between them.

No longer discovery.

No longer curiosity.

Expectation.

The restaurant kept moving around them.

Orders shouted.

Dishes clinking.

Laughter from a table near the window.

But Jenny felt separated from all of it now, like she was behind glass.

She lowered her voice.

"You said you're not leaving things undefined anymore."

Austin nodded.

"Yes."

"And what does that mean for me?"

A pause.

Then—

"It means I won't act like I don't know what you are to me."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"...And what am I to you?"

That question came out quieter than she intended.

More careful.

Austin didn't hesitate this time.

"You're not temporary."

Silence.

That word again.

But flipped.

Not temporary.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"That's not an answer," she said.

"It is," he replied.

"For where I stand."

Jenny crossed her arms tighter.

"You keep speaking like your position is the only one that matters."

Austin looked at her.

"I'm not ignoring yours."

"But you're defining yours first," she said.

A pause.

Then quietly—

"Yes."

That honesty hit harder than any denial would have.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Jenny felt it again.

That pressure.

Not from him.

From the space between them becoming too structured too quickly.

Too certain.

Too fast.

She finally said,

"You disappeared for days."

Austin didn't deny it.

"I did."

"And came back like you had already decided everything."

"I came back after deciding I couldn't keep pretending I hadn't."

That made her pause.

"...Pretending what?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then—

"That I could stay close to you without it becoming something real."

Silence.

That word again.

Real.

Jenny looked away briefly.

Of course she did.

When she spoke again, her voice was lower.

"You think this is real already?"

Austin shook his head slightly.

"No."

A pause.

"Not fully."

That surprised her.

Then he added,

"But it's no longer pretend."

That distinction mattered.

Too much.

Jenny stepped back slightly.

"You're making this heavier than it needs to be."

Austin didn't react defensively.

"I'm making it honest."

A pause.

Then—

"And honesty feels heavy when you've been surviving on ambiguity."

That landed uncomfortably close.

Jenny swallowed.

A customer called her name from across the room.

She didn't move immediately.

Bao stepped in again without comment.

He was watching everything now.

Not interfering.

Just witnessing.

When Jenny returned, Austin hadn't changed position.

Still there.

Still steady.

Still refusing to reduce what he had said.

She lowered her voice.

"So what do you expect from me?"

Austin answered immediately.

"Clarity."

That made her frown.

"I don't have clarity."

"I know," he said.

"I'm not asking you to match mine."

A pause.

"I'm asking you not to ignore it."

Silence.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"This feels like pressure."

Austin shook his head.

"It's presence."

"That's the same thing sometimes."

"Not to me," he said.

A pause.

Then softer—

"Pressure tries to change you quickly."

"I'm not trying to change you."

Jenny looked at him.

"...Then what are you doing?"

Austin held her gaze.

"Refusing to pretend I don't feel what I feel."

That landed differently.

No control.

No strategy.

Just exposure.

Jenny felt something shift again.

Not toward him.

Not away.

But somewhere unstable in between.

She looked down at the counter.

"I don't know how to respond to you anymore," she admitted quietly.

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

A pause.

Then—

"That's why I'm not asking for an answer yet."

Jenny looked up slightly.

"...Then what are you asking for?"

Austin hesitated for the first time in a while.

Then—

"Not to disappear from this just because it stops feeling comfortable."

Silence.

That sentence stayed.

Longer than anything else.

Jenny finally spoke.

"You're asking me to stay inside something I don't fully understand."

Austin didn't deny it.

"I'm asking you not to leave before you do."

That distinction mattered.

Too much.

The restaurant noise returned slowly into her awareness.

But something between them didn't return to normal.

Because now it wasn't about presence anymore.

It was about direction.

And neither of them could pretend they weren't already moving.

Jenny exhaled.

"I need time," she said again.

Austin nodded.

"I know."

But this time, he added quietly,

"And I won't reset myself while you take it."

Silence.

Jenny looked at him.

And realized something she didn't want to fully accept yet.

He wasn't waiting anymore.

He was staying.

And she was the one who had to decide what that meant.